Graphic Design

Newfound knowledge – Adobe Illustrator

Summary Notes

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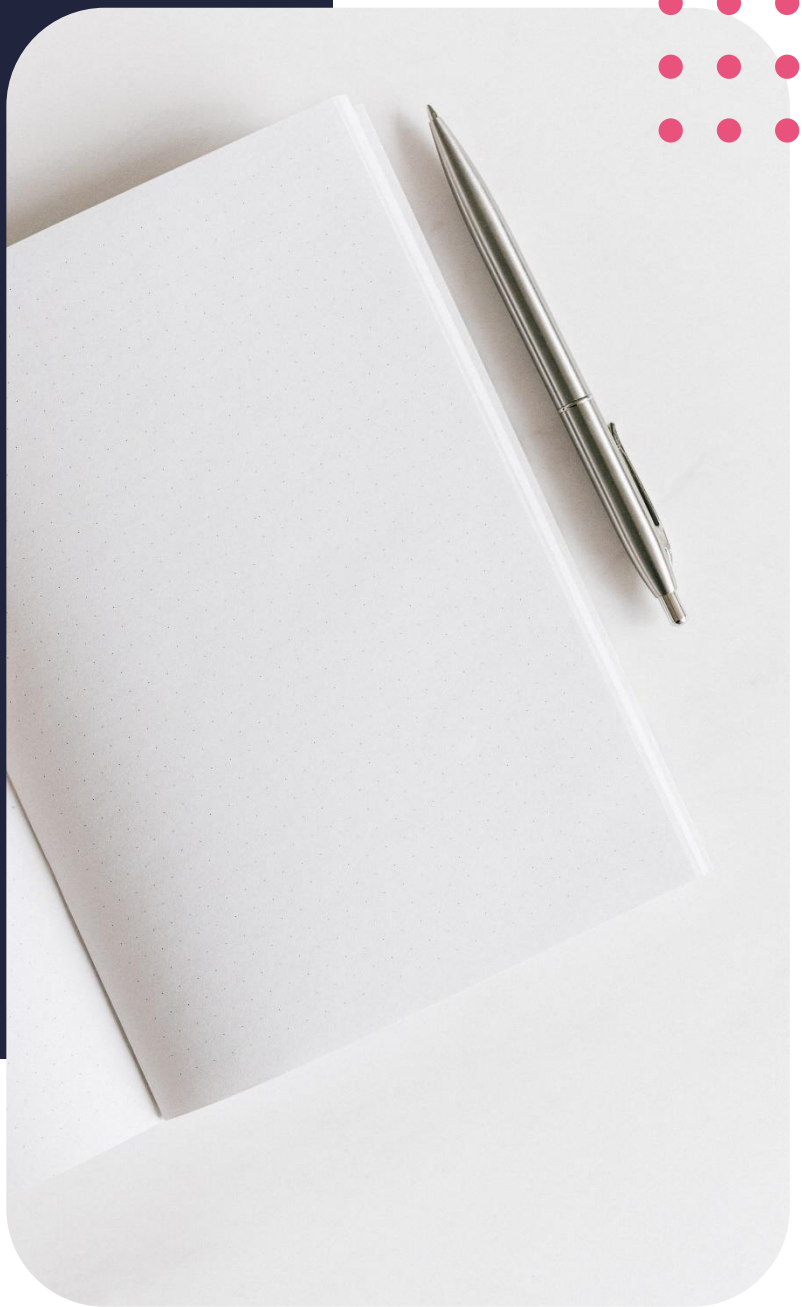


Introduction

I hope you have all created your logo we spoke about in the previous lesson as we will be using them in the flyer we will design soon. PLEASE make time to work in Illustrator as it is crucial for you to familiarise yourself with the interface. I would first like to provide you with some valuable information before we head onto designing. Our lesson today entails looking at the different type of images. In design terms we refer to two groups of images, raster and vector, I will then introduce you to the Works-everytime-layout and later in the lesson we will work on Illustrator again.

What is the difference between Adobe Illustrator & CorelDraw?

Image 1: Adobe Illustrator & CorelDraw – vector illustration applications

Before we start, I would like to answer a question a lot of students have: what is the difference between Adobe Illustrator and CorelDraw? CorelDraw is the opposition to Illustrator. It's like comparing BMW to Mercedes Benz. Both programs are excellent, and they basically provide the same functions. Some companies, mostly printing companies, prefer their designers to work in CorelDraw whereas other companies, mostly advertising agencies prefer Illustrator. I find Illustrator to be more popular since it correlates well with Photoshop and InDesign.

Raster images

To fully understand what a raster image is, we need to start at the smallest possible particle that builds up a raster image. A Pixel is a unit of measurement used in graphic design.

Pixel is short for picture element and a pixel is a single square of colour that represents the smallest part of an image. A pixel is roughly 1/96th of an inch or 0,26mm and is always square.

We can say that a raster image (aka bitmap) is an image made up of thousands and millions of pixels that are joined to form a whole - almost like a puzzle and its pieces. Photographs and most images you find on the internet are raster images. Raster images are normally measured in megapixels, like images taken by your phone or any other camera.

Image 2: Raster image

If you increase the size of a raster image, you lose data as you cannot add pixels that do not exist. We call this process pixilation. Please be very careful as pixilation is one of the first methods to identify a designer from a non-designer.

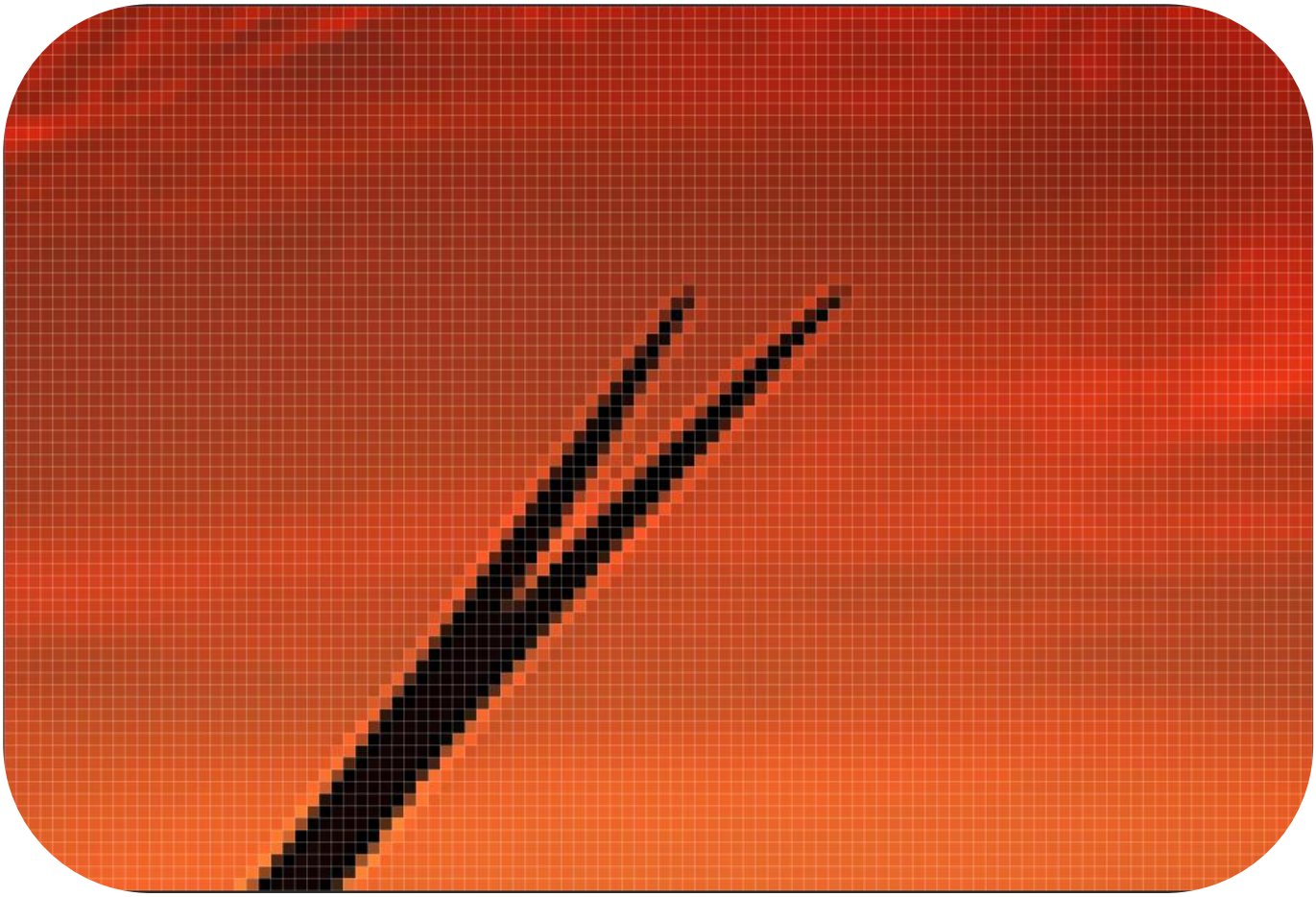
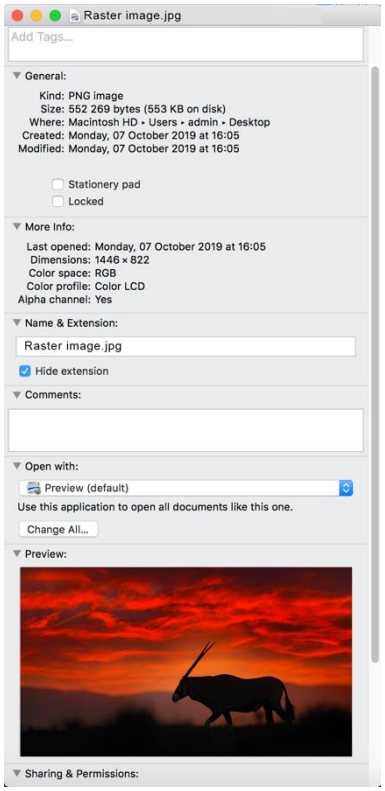


Image 3: The process of pixilation in a raster image



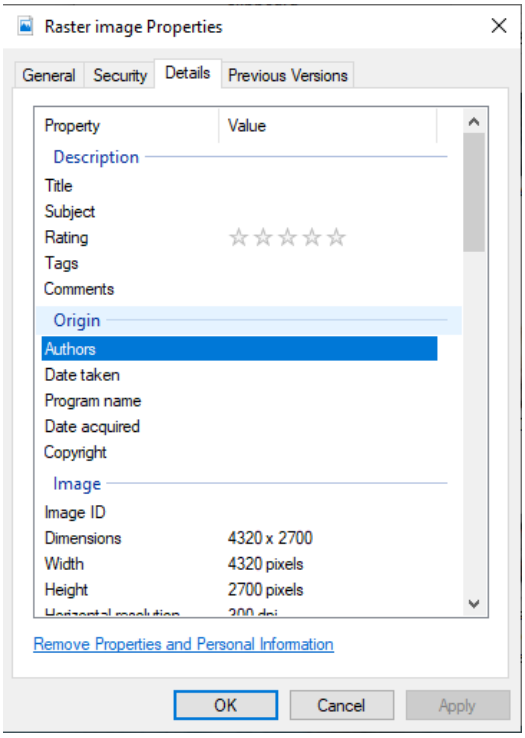
Raster or bitmap images usually end with .jpg, .png, .bmp, gif. and .tif

Image 4: Image details on an Apple Mac computer

To determine the number of pixels an image consists of, you simply multiply the pixel width by the height of an image. On a Mac you can simply right click on the image, go to “Get info”. Under the “More info” tab, you will notice a dimensions option.

Image 5: Image details on a MS Windows computer

To access this information on a Windows computer, simply right click on the photo as well, select properties and click on details. Under the "image" tab you will find the pixel dimensions.



Advantages & disadvantages of raster images

Advantages	Disadvantages
• Consist of continuous tones and thus easy to blend colours • Relatively easy to produce	• High resolution images take up a lot of disk space (suitable for printing) • Low resolution images are low in quality (suitable for digital use) • Cannot be enlarged as they will lose quality. You cannot add pixels that do not exist • Cannot be easily converted to vector

Vector images

A vector is an image created from mathematically defined geometric forms like lines, fills and shapes. They can be enlarged to any size without losing quality.

A good example of a vector image is any logo. Let's take Fred's logo for example.

Image 6: Vector image that does not pixilate

A vector image extensions end with .ai, .eps and .cdr

Vector images can easily be converted to raster images by simply exporting them using a vector-editing software like Illustrator or CorelDraw.

Kindly note that if you do not own a vector-editing software, that you will most likely not be able to open or use these files since vector images are mostly used by designers and speciality software is required to access these files.

Advantages & disadvantages of vector images

Advantages	Disadvantages
• Small file size, irrespective of the artwork size • Can be scaled infinitely without losing quality • Quick and easy to convert to raster	• Difficult to create continuous tone (blending of colours) • Only accessible on specialised software • Tedious to create

The works-every-time-layout

I would like to teach you a great technique that will help with almost any design. If you are serious about design, I can recommend the book - White space is not your enemy by Kim Golombisky & Rebecca Hagen. This book is full of graphic design theory and teaches beginners the essentials in a fun and interactive way. The technique that I would like to share with you is inspired by White Space is not your enemy. This technique is called the “Works-everytime-layout” and it’s called this because it does really work every time!

The Works-everytime-layout can be divided into 6 steps and these steps can be followed for almost any type of design. If you’re ever stuck in a creative rut, the works-everytime-layout is your go-to solution as well.

So, why does it work everytime? Simply because of the way we read and perceive things. Since human beings are visual and the fact that westerners read from left to right and top to bottom, this layout has been a success.

Image 7: Artwork created with the works-everytime-layout

The six steps are:

Step 1: Margins - Start your document by creating generous margins first - these will aid as a guide for all elements that should not be cut off.

Step 2: Columns - Then, simply add columns. The number of columns differ depending on the size of your layout. As we tend to read shorter sentences more easily and it creates the illusion of reading less, columns are a great way to retain your viewers' attention

Step 3: Visual - Have a visual at the top of your layout. Remember that we are visual beings, so this is a good way to attract your audience.

Step 4: Headline - the headline refers to the topic of your document. It should be right under the visual and be bold and exciting as this is the 2nd element your viewers would see after your visual.

Step 5: Copy - this refers to the text that will fill your document. Your copy can be placed in the column guides you created in step 2.

Step 6: Tags - a tag refers to additional information such as logos and contact details. Place this at the bottom right, where your viewer will exit the page.

Adobe Illustrator demo

The following are explained in the demo:

- Create your very first flyer in Adobe Illustrator
- Details are available in the starter pack
- Make use of the works-everytime-layout

By simply applying the works-everytime-layout and basic, but crucial features in Adobe Illustrator, you should receive a similar result to this. Please don't forget to focus on applying your elements and principles of design effectively. I am curious to see what you have come up with, so please share your final flyer on social media – this can be Facebook, Instagram, Pinterest or whatever you prefer using the #shawflyerdesign.

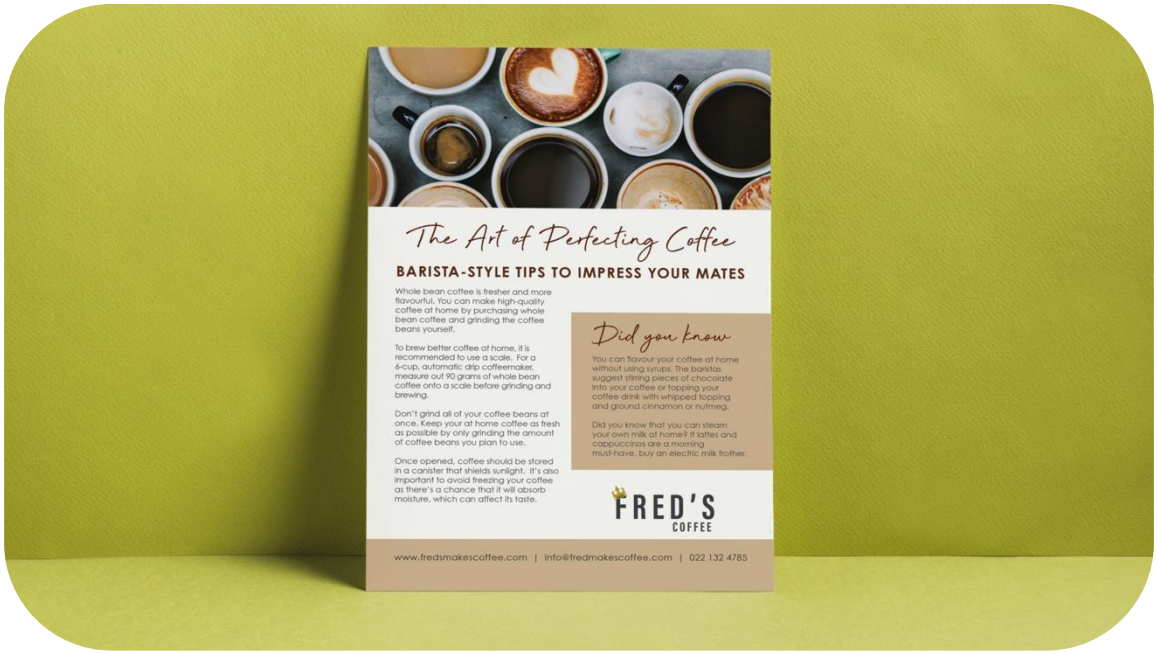


Image 8: Practical – artwork created with the works-everytime-layout

The more you practice, the better you will become and eventually by simply gaining more confidence, you should soon be able to create even more impressive designs.

Image 9: Practical – artwork created with the works-everytime-layout advanced technique

One thing is for sure, the works-everytime-layout does really work every time! The second option I created also made use of the works-everytime-layout but in a less traditional sense. Looking at how the elements have been applied and understanding Illustrator better, I am sure that you will be able to create a similar design. All elements on this design were done with the tools you have learnt in these lessons so far.

Bibliography

Hagen, R. & Golombisky, K. 2017, *White space is not your enemy: a beginner's guide to communicating visually through graphic, web & multimedia design*, 3rd ed. CRC Press, Boca Raton, Florida.